

A different beat



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Editor

"Four or five Digit employees *may* not be able to do much, but four or five lakh Digit readers and friends *will* make a difference!"

When Team Digit sat down this month to create the issue you're holding in your hands, we actually had a very regular, run-of-the-mill security issue planned. We were thinking PC security all along, and the more we talked about the stories we'd cover, the less we liked our own ideas.

Finally, we decided to go out and get some more real-world stories, and write a report or two. Over the past fortnight or so, the Digit Team has been out on the town. We searched for and found unsecured Wi-Fi connections, then rang doorbells and told people about them. We've gone out and shopped using credit cards that aren't ours, and then signed ridiculous names on the purchase slips, just to see if we'd get away with it. We decided to look at everyday life, and find security flaws in the technology we use.

I actually had a friend ask me, "Why?". He was referring to the effort the team was putting in to do all this. Could we really change anything? Would malls really start training their cashiers to do even cursory checks on credit card signatures just because Digit decided to buy a few things with fake signatures? Would all Indians magically start caring about securing their wireless routers, or even know how to, just because of an article in Digit?

Sadly, the answer is no.

However, if dreamers let reality and inertia get in the way of trying, the world would still be rubbing flint together to start a fire, taking shelter under a rock somewhere in Africa. Personally, I'd rather dream and try to make a difference, than sit around and crib about what's wrong with the world. I'm pretty sure you want to do the same, but where and how do we start?

One huge difference that I think we can all make is to be a little more patient and understanding. I've noticed people being restless when waiting to pay a bill, or when we're in line waiting to be frisked when we enter a mall. One cashier that I confronted, when he didn't check my credit card signature actually felt that people

didn't like their identity questioned, because they found it insulting or embarrassing.

Why would I be embarrassed or insulted if someone took the trouble to secure a transaction on my credit card? However, a quick poll of friends later, I've found that this is, sadly, true. If we can accept frisking in airports as a necessary means to safeguard our lives, why can't we apply the same logic everywhere else?

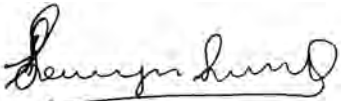
The first step we can all do is change ourselves. I suggest you start by pointing out when cashiers don't check your signature. Also, before you leave, tell them that you will have to reconsider shopping there in the future, as they don't seem to care about their customers' security. That ought to get them to consider checking signatures, at least for the next few people in line.

If you come across an unsecured Wi-Fi connection in your building, follow signal strength, ring a door bell and help your neighbours secure themselves.

We just have to lead by example, and march to a different beat. Four or five Digit employees may not be able to do much, but four or five lakh Digit readers and your friends, *will* make a difference. Trust me.

On a different note, we also decided to try and make Digit more interactive this month, with our *Crack the Code* contest (details on page 109), and since a lot of us are pixel art fans, we figured what better way than to start the game from the cover itself, with clues hidden in a pixel art cover. Our design team worked overtime this month adding in all the little details we demanded — we hope you like it.

I hope to get feedback from you on this issue — about the cover, the thoughts on this page, and all the stories within — so write in to the email address below, or use one of the other interaction points and share your experiences and ideas with the team and me. **d**


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